

2. 'There is little future in the arts.' How true is this of your society?

KEY TERMS

The arts (<https://www.britannica.com/topic/the-arts>)

- the arts are modes of expression that use skill or imagination in the creation of aesthetic objects, environments, or experiences that can be shared with others
- traditional categories within the arts include:
 - literature (including poetry, drama, story, and so on)
 - the visual arts (painting, drawing, sculpture, etc.)
 - the performing arts (theatre, dance, music), music (as composition)
 - architecture (often including interior design)
 - graphic arts (painting, drawing, design, and other forms expressed on flat surfaces)
 - the plastic arts (sculpture, modeling)
 - the decorative arts (enamelwork, furniture design, mosaic, etc.)

Little future

- Limited, not much
 - Career and development prospects
 - Possibly having a dismissive tone

SUGGEST STAND

While the future for artists in Singapore is perceived to be bleak, yet upon closer examination, we find that there are in fact possibilities.

Question requirement (Conceptual Understanding)

- A recognition that **many aspects of Singapore**/Singaporeans (SES, economics, education, culture, history, socio-cultural developments, etc.) will **impact the relevance** of the arts and hence its future for aspiring artists.

APPROACH

- A. Explain why there is the perception that there is little future in the arts.
- B. Explain why, on closer examination, we find that a future in the arts is actually possible.

ARGUMENTS

A. Explain why there is the perception that there is little future in the arts.

A1. Singapore is a very small nation with a relatively small population. This effectively limits the domestic market for the arts which is where most artists begin their careers.

In most population, the number of people with artistic talent or with the interest and capacity for supporting the arts is proportional to the total population. The smaller the population, the smaller the talent pool and the smaller the number of patrons. Even if they have the money, they might not have an interest in the arts or consider them worthy of their support. This significantly reduce the patronage that artists can expect. Without patronage, artists are hard put to make a living much less have a future.

Evidence

- *In 2021, the Singapore Department of Statistics reports that the population is 5.45 million, of which 526,000 are millionaires but only 4206 are considered ultra-high-net-worth individuals. With the high cost of living in Singapore, especially the cost of housing, the reality is that many of these millionaires are in fact asset rich but cash poor. For many, their money is tied up in the property they own and live in or is invested in their businesses. They often do not have the liquidity to invest in the arts, hence there is little patronage for artists because good art is expensive.*
- *According to Singaporean gallerists, the price for an artwork by relatively young and unknown Singaporean artists starts in the low thousands and can go up to tens of thousands and more given the cost of materials and the time they had put in to create the artworks. However, the average income of Singaporeans is S\$5,783 (January 2022), the Median Gross Monthly Income is S\$4,563 which is significantly lower, and the disposable income is further reduced to by 30% to S\$3,194 by the compulsory monthly CPF contributions (employer 17% and employee 20%). A reasonable living wage in Singapore is S\$2,906 (Channel News Asia, 8 October 2021) and a family of four needs S\$6,426 a month for a basic standard of living. There is little leftover for buying artworks and so artists will find few buyers for their artworks.*

A2a. The problem is compounded by the prevailing view of the arts, famously articulated by the late Mr Lee Kuan Yew, the first Prime Minister of Singapore, 'the arts is a luxury we cannot afford.' The influence of Mr Lee on the national ethos cannot be underestimated. He might be dead but his legacy lives on and continues to underpin governmental policies and public opinion, hence the arts does not receive as much governmental support as science-technology-engineering-mathematics.

The governmental view of the importance of the arts has severely limited the opportunities for aspiring artists to gain the exposure, education and training so essential to their development, recognition and future. This is evidenced by the lack of resources and attention given to the arts by the government and especially in schools. It is often considered enrichment, peripheral rather than essential, may be good to have but not important. This often results in a non-beginning, hence little hope for a future in the arts.

Evidence:

- *6 Autonomous, i.e. government subsidized universities – National University of Singapore, Nanyang **Technological** University, Singapore University of **Technology** and Design, Singapore Institute of **Technology**, Singapore University of Social **Sciences** and Singapore Management University. It is noteworthy that 4 of them has science or technology in their names, clearly an indication of their focus and orientation. The most established university in Singapore, NUS has a total enrollment, in 2021/2022, of 31272, but there are only 224 enrolled in the Yong Siew Toh Conservatory of Music and 673 in the architecture faculty, which is applied arts rather than the fine arts. NTU which has the School of Art, Design and Media has more vacancies but the focus is on the practical application of art in design and media than for the arts per se.*
- *In March 2021, the then Education Minister Lawrence Wong announced that a new university of the arts will be formed by an alliance between the Nanyang Academy of Fine Arts and Lasalle*

College of the Arts. It will be first university of the arts in Singapore. While the new university will have the support of the government, be granted degree-awarding powers and status of a university, it will be a private university, not an autonomous one which means that it will not have the prestige or the financial support that the other local universities have.

A2b. Many Singaporeans continue see the arts as a luxury, not an essential and in the competition with other luxuries, the arts is very much an also ran. There are so many other luxuries fighting for the attention of Singaporeans and these **are more actively promoted and more heavily funded than the arts.** They are also often more affordable and available. As a luxury item, the arts is often less accessible for the general public. It is often considered **high-brow, requiring specialist knowledge to be appreciated and enjoyed.** It is for the intellectuals and not the masses, a select minority and not the majority. Hence, a future in the arts is often considered a pipe dream.

Evidence:

- In Singapore, there are about 50 art galleries and 11 dedicated concert halls and theatres, but at least 171 shopping malls, with many retail outlets in each of them and most will devote at least one to two levels to luxury shops. An entire street, Orchard Road, is devoted to shopping malls and in virtually every housing estate, there will be at least one mall and many small retail outlets.*
- A Louis Vuitton is a Louis Vuitton and a Rolex watch is a Rolex watch. They need neither training nor specialist knowledge to be enjoyed or to attract attention and envy. The masses recognize them and the owners gain satisfaction knowing that others appreciate the value of the items whereas the arts is so much more esoteric. Since the majority do not need or appreciate the artworks, the artists will find it hard to find support for the creation and sale of their works.*

A3a. Singaporeans are pragmatic. Our history, which records the founding of Singapore and the factors that drew the pioneer generation, is suffused with pragmatism. The current Singapore government continues to place a lot of emphasis on the economy, with the resultant stress on the STEM subjects which are directly related to the economy and significantly less on the arts.

Evidence:

- Sir Stamford Raffles founded Singapore as a British trading post.*
- The pioneer generation came to Singapore to make a living.*
- As reported by the Straits Times, the 2022 budget blocks out SG\$109 billion in spending for the fiscal year, and authorizes drawing on up to SG\$6 billion in past reserves. The proposed budget are pivoted on three key areas: creating an active economy, a beautiful society and a clean environment. Note that economic concerns is first and beautiful society' does not reference the arts but social structures and values.*
- In schools, the arts, painting and music are usually non-examinable subjects and in most secondary schools, not offered as a subject beyond secondary two. Even when they are offered, only a small number take them up. In Nanyang Junior College, which offers Arts Elective, the*

average number of students for each cohort is less than thirty whereas the cohorts for the sciences - Biology, Chemistry and Physics - average two hundred and above out a total of about seven hundred students. The number of students taking literature is similarly small and this is common in other colleges and schools and in most schools, music is not even offered as a subject.

A3b There is a common perception among many Singaporeans that **the arts do not provide one with a viable career option**. Some young artists in Singapore do **face hurdles in pursuing a full-time art career**. Industry experts and veterans also agree that it remains very difficult for young Singaporeans to pursue artistic careers full-time. Hence, parents in Singapore discourage their children from pursuing the arts. At the end of the day, the starving artist in the turrel is not what most pragmatic Singaporeans would envision for themselves or their children.

- Ben Loong earns up to S\$400 a month as a Grab driver to supplement his income from his art. While he makes just enough in total to cover his rent and expenses. Ben's experience is not unique among artists in Singapore. Ceramic artist Ummu Nabilah, 24, returns home from her day job as an art teacher in the evenings, only to stay up till 2am working on pottery. She makes a few hundred dollars in profit from the sale of each batch of 15 pottery items, with each item costing up to S\$30. For freelance performer Michelle Ler, 23, the biggest struggle in pursuing a career in the arts is the instability of it all. Unlike her friends from other universities who settled into one job after going through multiple interviews, the Lasalle graduate described her artistic career as "a never-ending job interview". "You get a job. It lasts from a few weeks to a month, and then it's the same cycle again."
- From driving a private-hire car to part-time teaching, almost every artist interviewed by TODAY holds more than one job — as a safeguard against the irregularity and, in some cases, the low pay of the projects they undertake.
- it was reported in May 2017 that only three in 10 Sota graduating students went on to pursue arts-related university courses.

A3c. While an **investment** in the arts - visual, performing or literary arts – has the potential for a good return to amount invested, **it is a lot less certain than investing in shares and commodities, in businesses or their careers**. Most of the alternatives provide more regular and certain returns, like dividends if one is invested in blue-chip companies, profits and salaries. Liquidity may also be greater. Hence **pragmatic Singaporeans would rather invest in the things that provide greater certainty** than in the arts or the artists. Furthermore, the **sums needed for such investments are often much smaller than the outlay for the arts, making them more affordable**.

Singaporean artists are relatively unknown in the international market, which limits their exposure and investment potentials. **Selling the artworks may be more challenging because of the lack of international fame**... Therefore, Singaporeans investors are more likely to **invest in internationally established artists then in local artists**, which hinders their prospects. It does not help that many investments in artistic endeavours are actually money losing undertakings.

Evidence:

- *The cheapest stock on the Singapore Stock Exchange is Cnergy, traded at S\$0.004 per share on 28 August 2022. Given that shares are bought in lots of 100 units, the minimal investment is only \$0.40 compared to the thousands and even millions needed for the arts. The most expensive stock on the same day is Jardine Matheson Holding which traded at about S\$72.50, 100 units of that is only S\$7200.50 which is a lot more affordable. Share prices for the 3 local banks, DBS, OCBC and UOB are \$32.51, \$20.04 and \$11.97 respectively. They give regular dividend unlike artworks whose value may appreciate but need to be sold for gains to be realized.*
- *The Singapore Symphonic Orchestra operating expenses in 2021 is S\$19.6 million. The income from ticket sales is S\$0.12 million. The reason it continues to exist is the governmental support given to it.*

B. Explain why, on closer examination, we find that a future in the arts is actually possible.

B1. Rebuttal of A1 – geography and economics – small nation

Singapore may be a **small nation, but** it is also **a globalized city**. While the Singapore art circle may be relatively small, it is the gateway to South-east Asia, the Far East and the world. Artists in Singapore are well placed to access this greater community. Singaporean artists are also gaining international recognition and access and within Singapore, they are establishing a presence.

Evidence

- *Sotheby, a major international art auction house, held a modern and contemporary art sale in Singapore in August 2022. Previously their auctions were held in Hong Kong rather than Singapore. While the artworks on auction may not all be Singaporean artworks, yet it provided an important platform for local artists and art collectors.*
- *Singaporean artists are gaining international recognition, most famously and successfully is possibly artist Tan Swie Hian. Tan Swie Hian's work has been offered at auction multiple times, with realized prices ranging from US\$1,485 USD to US\$3,370,979, depending on the size and medium of the artwork. Since 2012 the record price for this artist at auction is US\$3,370,979 for Portrait of Bada Shanren sold at Poly International Auction Co. in 2014.*
- *There is now a growing group of local artists whose talents demonstrate a depth and scope that is particularly striking – some well-established and others just starting to make a name for themselves – for they are at the same time performers, editors, comedians and activists. Through their works, they grapple with the issues of a generation, such as feminism, queerness and mental health. Some of them include:*
 - *Topaz Winters, author. She is youngest Singaporean to be nominated for the Pushcart Prize, and is the writer and star of critically acclaimed short film Supernova, creator of digital art installation Love Lives Bot on Twitter, and the writer of poetry collection Portrait of My Body as a Crime I'm Still Committing.*

- *Deborah Emmanuel, poet, singer and theatre-maker. Her poems have been featured at the festivals like the Barcelona International Poetry Festival and has won competitions in Singapore, Germany and Australia. She also presents live performances of her poetry.*
- *Venezia May has published two anthologies in London, won the Causeway Exchange Slam in 2018 and 2019, and conducts workshops for special needs children. She has performed at the Esplanade and Poetry Festival Singapore 2019.*
- *Stephanie Dogfoot Chan, poet and host of Spoke & Bird, a monthly open mic for poets from all walks of life. She represented Singapore in international slam competitions and has toured globally with their poetry.*

B2a. Rebuttal of A3 – pragmatism of Singaporeans

Furthermore, as **Singaporeans become more affluent and educated**, there is a growing interest in the arts and support for the artists. More and more Singaporeans are awakening to the **conviction that pragmatism cannot be the sole basis of worth**. Singapore is maturing as a society and the arts are likewise developing and offering more opportunities for artists as there is greater awareness and increasing value placed on the arts. Many younger Singaporeans, unlike the older generation, no longer consider the arts a luxury we cannot afford. Instead the view may be that is not a luxury, but an essential element in a cultured, civilized society. Even for those who may still consider the arts a luxury, yet because of the increased affluence of Singaporeans, it has become a luxury that a significant number of them can afford.

There is also discernable shift towards a more knowledge based (smart) economy where ‘artistic’ skills (creativity, innovation and originality, 21st century skills) are in demand and have direct relevance to jobs (graphic arts, decorative arts, performing arts and architecture) and so the arts can be lucrative options (career, business or investment).

Evidence

- *A report in the Straits Times highlights that employers, because of COVID restrictions which impacted their interactions with clients, are awakening to the fact that people trained in the arts may be better suited to the changed working environment where creativity and communication skills, the forte of artists, are more significant in the new economy than the traditional STEM professionals. While it might not be the arts per se, yet it is a future for artists, especially those involved the ‘practical’ arts or whose talents and skills can be applied.*
- *A survey by the National Arts Council shows that more Singaporeans are recognising the benefits and value of the arts. On average 78 percent of the population acknowledge that the arts help foster a sense of belonging, community and identity as well as inspiring creativity and innovation. The overall level of interest in the arts has also risen with 41 percent of the respondents saying they are interested in the arts.*